

Junior Assembly of the Model United Nations (JAMUN)

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501(c)(3) nonprofit

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Lilly Endowment Inc.
2801 North Meridian Street
Indianapolis, IN 46208

Dear Members of the Grants Committee:

I write on behalf of the Junior Assembly of the Model United Nations (JAMUN), a 501(c)(3) nonprofit, to introduce our organization and to respectfully request the Endowment's consideration of a **\$15,000 grant** to extend JAMUN's highly successful flagship Chicagoland Model UN conference into and across Indiana, with a particular focus on under-resourced schools. The requested funds would build the digital training and in-person onboarding that allow Indiana schools — most of which have no Model UN program of their own — to prepare and field delegations at the conference for the first time.

About JAMUN. JAMUN was founded on a simple conviction: that a middle-school student from any background should be able to compete in high-quality academic enrichment. Model UN, Mock Trial, and programs like them have long been the province of well-resourced schools, and we exist to change that. We design our programs specifically for grades 5–8 — the age at which students benefit most from early exposure to public speaking, structured debate, and self-directed research, and the age that most Model UN programs do not yet serve. Our model rests on three commitments: every curriculum guide, training video, and coaching resource we produce is published free online; conference registration is kept deliberately low-cost; and our grant program covers **up to 100% of conference costs** — registration, travel, and materials — for any family that needs support. To date, JAMUN has served **500+ students from 30+ schools**, supported by **80+ volunteer coaches and chairs** and **\$70,000+ in donor-funded program scholarships**.

The need we seek to address. The skills JAMUN teaches — disciplined argument, respectful disagreement, the patience to research before speaking, the willingness to be persuaded by a better idea — are precisely the character and leadership capacities the Endowment has identified as foundational to youth development. Yet for middle-schoolers these opportunities are scarce on two fronts at once. Very few Model UN programs admit students this young, and the handful that do are clustered in a few major metropolitan areas and elite private schools. So for an eighth-grader in Indianapolis, Fort Wayne, or a rural Indiana district, the nearest age-appropriate conference is often a state away — and even where one is within reach, its participation costs (registration, transportation, lodging, materials) routinely exceed what a public-school family or a Title I school's club budget can absorb. The opportunity is at once too rare and too expensive, and the students who would gain the most from it are the ones least able to reach it.

Our proposed project. JAMUN's Chicagoland conference is already within driving distance of much of Indiana, so reaching Indiana students does not call for a new conference — it calls for

removing the two barriers that keep them away: they have no Model UN program at their own schools to prepare them, and no established path to get to ours. The requested **\$15,000** would fund a specific set of developments — digital and physical — that directly close that gap:

- **A digital onboarding-and-training track built for first-time Indiana schools.** A self-guided online program, paired with live virtual coaching in the weeks before the conference, that lets a teacher with no Model UN experience — anywhere in the state — prepare a competitive delegation from scratch. This is what makes participation possible for schools that have no club, no faculty advisor, and no older students to learn from.
- **In-person introductory workshops in Indiana, and the logistics to get delegations to the conference.** Short, on-the-ground training sessions hosted at Indiana schools and community sites to recruit and ready new delegates, together with the coordinated group travel and on-site support for first-time delegations that turn a conference a few hours away into one an Indiana student can actually attend.

These developments adapt our proven conference to serve students arriving from a new state, rather than leaving Indiana schools to overcome distance and inexperience on their own.

Why this aligns with the Endowment's priorities. The Endowment's recent investments in character development, leadership formation, and equitable access for young people in under-resourced communities reflect a conviction we share: that the academic and civic skills middle-schoolers acquire shape the adults — and the citizens — they become. JAMUN's pedagogy — students writing their own position papers, defending them on the floor, negotiating with peers across genuine difference — is character formation in practice, not in theory. Extending this work to Indiana students who currently have no realistic path into it is, we believe, a small but meaningful contribution to the Endowment's broader mission for the state's young people.

Funding request. We respectfully request **\$15,000** to develop and launch the digital training track and the in-person Indiana workshops and delegation support described above. JAMUN intends this work as the foundation for a lasting Indiana presence — a growing roster of Indiana schools whose students prepare through our free resources and compete each year at the Chicagoland conference — sustained over the long term by conference registration revenue, local philanthropic support, and continued donor giving. The Endowment's early support would be catalytic: at JAMUN's current stage, \$15,000 is the difference between Indiana being a state we hope to serve and one we actually do.

I would welcome the opportunity to provide any additional information the Endowment may find helpful, including our project budget, board roster, IRS determination letter, audited financials, and references from partner schools and educators. I can be reached at contact@jamun.org or by mail at the address above.

Thank you for your time, and for the consistent leadership the Lilly Endowment has shown in supporting young people across Indiana.

Respectfully,

Joshua Varon
Founder & Executive Director
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